calls the new initiatives ‘The Maritime Silk Road’ and the ‘One Belt One Road’ and reiterates its assertion that its only aim is to peacefully promote trade in the region.[47]

The port project in Obock will, according to China’s own admission, become a base for anti-piracy operations which its fleet carries out in the area and, therefore, represents no threat to other powers. But Obock will nevertheless be China’s first military base abroad, as Chinese planes will be stationed there. Even Gwadar will have an airfield and combined with the facility at Obock, this means increased freedom of movement for the Chinese Air Force outside the country. The US is already in the area, in Djibouti as well as on Diego Garcia, a British possession in the Indian Ocean where it established a large air and naval base in the 1970s. Diego Garcia has been used extensively during the United States’ wars on Afghanistan and Iraq.

Meanwhile, Chinese submarines have already been observed in the Indian Ocean, mainly around the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, north of the entrance to the Strait of Malacca. The Indian Navy says it encounters Chinese submarines at least once a month, which is not so surprising given the volume of Chinese trade and oil supplies through the Indian Ocean. But it is a completely new development in a maritime region where, only two decades ago, China was not present at all. India and the United States now co-operate to detect and identify Chinese submarines.

France is another, almost unknown, Indian Ocean power with close relations to India and the United States. There are two inhabited French *départements d’outre-mer* (overseas departments) in the Indian Ocean, Mayotte and Réunion, which thus also are part of the European Union. In addition, France controls the relatively large Kerguelen Island, the smaller St. Paul and Amsterdam Islands, the Crozet Archipelago, and a series of small islands around Madagascar. Only Mayotte and Réunion have permanent populations, but there are French scientists and military personnel on the other islands and Kerguelen has a satellite monitoring station. In total, France’s Economic Exclusive Zone in the southern Indian Ocean consists of more than 2.5 million square kilometres.

Australia, another partner in the informal alliance, possesses Christmas Island, south of Java and, further out in the Indian Ocean, the Cocos (Keeling) Islands. These territories have a combined population of just over 3,000, but there is a big airstrip on the Cocos, as well as extensive